

Skills

Assessing Apical-Radial Pulse

Checklist

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S = Satisfactory U = Unsatisfactory NP = Not Performed

Step	S	U	NP	Comments
Verified the health care provider's orders.	☐	☐	☐	
Gathered the necessary equipment and supplies.	☐	☐	☐	
Performed hand hygiene.	☐	☐	☐	
Introduced self to the patient and family.	☐	☐	☐	
Provided for the patient's privacy.	☐	☐	☐	
Identified the patient using two patient identifiers.	☐	☐	☐	
Checked for factors that suggest a possible pulse deficit. Obtained the help of a second health care provider.	☐	☐	☐	
Explained to the patient that two people will be assessing heart function at the same time. Helped the patient into a supine or sitting position, and exposed the sternum and left side of the chest.	☐	☐	☐	
Located the apical and radial pulse sites. Had the second health care provider palpate the radial pulse while they auscultated the apical pulse.	☐	☐	☐	
Counted the pulse rate simultaneously for a full 60 seconds.	☐	☐	☐	
Stopped counting and compared findings.	☐	☐	☐	
Subtracted the radial rate from the apical rate.	☐	☐	☐	
Helped the patient into a comfortable position.	☐	☐	☐	

Discussed findings with the patient as needed.

Performed hand hygiene.

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Assessed for other signs and symptoms of decreased cardiac output.

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Reported the presence of a pulse deficit and any related symptoms to the nurse in charge or to the health care provider.

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Helped the patient into a comfortable position, and placed toiletries and personal items within reach.

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Placed the call light within easy reach, and made sure the patient knew how to use it to summon assistance.

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Raised the appropriate number of side rails and lowered the bed to the lowest position.

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Disposed of used supplies and equipment. Left the patient's room tidy.

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Removed and disposed of gloves. Performed hand hygiene.

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Documented and reported the patient's response and expected or unexpected outcomes.

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Learner: _____
Evaluator: _____
Date: _____

Signature: _____
Signature: _____